Leads Aren’t Pipeline

What Is Lead Generation (Really)?

CHAPTER 1 — Is Lead Generation Just Collecting Emails? (0:00–0:45)

If 1,000 leads meant revenue,
every company with a webinar would be rich.
The problem isn’t volume — it’s what happens after the form fill.

Lead generation sounds simple: you just generate leads.
But what even counts as a lead?

Is it an ebook download?
A webinar signup?
A pricing page visit?
A demo request?

Most teams get stuck right here.
Because they treat lead generation like one activity.

Here’s what most people miss:
leads aren’t pipeline.

A list of emails is not revenue.
It’s contact information.

Real lead generation is a system.
It attracts the right buyers, captures their info, qualifies their intent,
and turns the right ones into real sales conversations.

If any part of that breaks, everything downstream breaks.

Some teams think lead gen ends at “someone filled out a form.”
But that’s just the start.
If you stop there, you didn’t build pipeline —
you built a list that feels busy and converts poorly.

In the next minute, I’ll show you the four stages this system has to go through —
and then we’ll answer the question most teams don’t ask until it’s too late:
where leads actually come from, and how to tell if yours are any good.

Let’s dive in.

CHAPTER 2 — The Four Stages That Have to Happen (0:45–2:15)

Lead generation isn’t one step.
It’s four stages that have to happen in order:

Attract
Capture
Qualify
Convert

Stage one: Attract
This is how buyers first find you.
Content, SEO, social, ads — anything that puts you in front of people who have the problem you solve.

If you attract the wrong people,
everything else becomes cleanup work.

Stage two: Capture
This is where someone gives you contact info
in exchange for something useful.

This is where most teams stop and say,
“Cool, we’re doing lead gen.”

But capture is not pipeline.
Capture is a list.

Stage three: Qualify and nurture
Not every contact is a real buyer.
Some are students.
Some are competitors.
Some are the wrong company size.
Some are just early in research mode.

This is where you separate curiosity from intent.

Stage four: Convert to pipeline
This is where qualified leads turn into real sales conversations.
Meetings booked.
Opportunities created.
Deals actually move forward.

Most teams fail by stopping at stage two.
They collect emails, celebrate volume,
and then wonder why revenue doesn’t follow.

Once you see these four stages,
the next question becomes tactical:
where do leads actually come from —
and which channels are worth your time?

CHAPTER 3 — Where Do Leads Actually Come From? (2:15–3:45)

Leads can come from a lot of places:
ads, SEO, outbound, events, referrals, social.

The mistake is trying to do all of them at once.

A cleaner way to think about channels is owned versus paid.

Owned channels are what you control:
your website
your content
email nurture
webinars you host
customer referrals

Owned channels take time to build,
but they compound over time and lower your cost per lead.

Paid channels are what you rent:
ads
outbound
sponsored placements

Paid channels give you speed.
But the moment you stop paying, volume drops.

The strategy is balance.
Use paid when you need pipeline now.
Use owned to build a lead engine that compounds over time.

The second mistake is spreading budget across too many channels.
You don’t need ten channels.
You need three or four that match how your buyers actually behave.

Enterprise buyers often respond to outbound, LinkedIn, and events.
SMB buyers often discover through SEO and search ads.
Developers often respond to content and product-led motions.

And that leads to the most important question:
you might generate 500 leads —
but are they good?

CHAPTER 4 — How to Tell If a Lead Is Good (3:45–5:30)

A lead is only “good” relative to two things:
fit and intent.

Fit means: is this the kind of company and role you can actually sell to?
Intent means: are they showing signals they might buy now?

Someone downloading an ebook is not the same as someone requesting a demo.
Someone at a 10-person startup is not the same as someone at a 500-person company in your target industry.

This is where lead types help.

MQL — Marketing Qualified Lead
Engaged with content, showing interest, but not sales-ready yet.

SQL — Sales Qualified Lead
Vetted for fit and buying readiness.
Ready for a sales conversation.

PQL — Product Qualified Lead
Common in SaaS.
Product usage shows real buying intent — like hitting an activation threshold in a free trial.

Expansion lead
An existing customer signaling upgrade or expansion interest.

Now you score leads by fit plus intent.

Fit:
job title
company size
industry

Intent:
demo requests
pricing page visits
high-intent content
email engagement

This is how you stop treating all leads the same.

Calling a six-month-old ebook download
with the same urgency as yesterday's demo request
is how sales teams waste time.

Once you score and prioritize, the next conflict shows up in every company:
who actually owns lead generation — marketing or sales?

CHAPTER 5 — Who's Responsible: Marketing or Sales? (5:30–7:00)

Marketing generates leads.
Sales generates leads.
Product generates leads.

Everyone's right —
but they generate different types.

Marketing drives awareness and early interest.
Sales creates demand through targeted outreach.
Product creates demand through usage and trials.

The problem isn't ownership.
The problem is handoffs and definitions.

Marketing says sales doesn't follow up.
Sales says marketing sends junk.

That tension kills pipeline.

The fix is alignment on definitions and handoffs.
What counts as qualified.
When a lead moves to sales.
How fast follow-up happens.
How feedback loops improve quality.

When that's aligned, lead gen becomes a system instead of finger-pointing.

So what do you actually do today if your lead gen feels inconsistent?

CHAPTER 6 — What to Do Today (7:00–8:30)

Here’s the bottom line.

Lead generation isn’t collecting emails.
It’s a four-stage system:
attract, capture, qualify, convert.

Here’s what to do this week:

First, audit your system.
Are you doing all four stages —
or just attracting and capturing?

Second, define what “qualified” means.
What behaviors show intent?
What fit criteria matter?
Build a simple scoring model.

Third, pick three or four channels.
Choose based on buyer behavior.
Balance short-term pipeline with long-term compounding channels.

Fourth, fix handoffs.
Agree on what counts as sales-ready.
Agree on response time.
Build feedback loops.

And one honest note:
you don’t need more leads
if you already can’t handle the ones you have.

If you’re getting volume and pipeline is still flat,
the problem isn’t lead gen.
It’s qualification and follow-up speed.

Lead gen isn’t magic.
It’s sequencing.

Get the sequence right, and pipeline follows.
Get it wrong, and you stay busy without growing.

Three Hook Options (first 2–3 lines)

Hook Option 1 (Direct + punchy)

Leads aren’t pipeline.
A list of emails doesn’t pay your bills.
If you’re collecting leads and still missing quota, the system is broken upstream.

Hook Option 2 (Pattern break)

If 1,000 leads meant revenue,
every company with a webinar would be rich.
The problem isn’t volume — it’s what happens after the form fill.

Hook Option 3 (Relatable pain)

You’ve got leads coming in.
Sales is still complaining.
And pipeline still feels unpredictable.
That’s not a volume problem — that’s a system problem.